The Block Party

By Joseph Lizardi

Lena, known as a pretty neighborhood prostitute, has just returned from a job interview, angry and frustrated.

LENA: Been a long day. Long, hard day. Went for a job, you know. A decent job. Secretary. Well, a receptionist. Saw it advertised in El Diario. Didn't get it. He said I ain't got the right kind of voice. Whatever that means. Really wanted that job, you know. I practiced every day. "Good morning, Damon Enterprises, Incorporated." That was the name of the company. "Good morning, Damon Enterprises, Incorporated." Everybody 'round here said I sounded great. Perfect, you know. A whole week practicing. But at the interview, he said I looked good but sounded terrible. Wanted to spit on his face. But you know what I did? Begged him to try me somewhere else. So he asked if I could type, so I lied. So he put me in front of this typewriter – and I tried to type. Everybody laughed at me. I was a big joke.

INTRODUCTION

Prostitution is the oldest profession in the world. According to US Health Department (March 2016), the average female prostitute enters the profession when she is only 14 years of age. And although it is extremely clear that these young women want out -- 92 percent of them say they can't escape due to a lack of money or food. In this selection, Lena discovers that leaving the profession is not as easy as she had hoped. The Block Party by John Lizardi

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

LENA: I know everybody 'round here laugh when I say I wanna get out of all this, but I do. I really do. I don't enjoy what it do. Never did. I hate it. Nothing to be proud, you know. So degrading, you know. I really

hate those creep(s) when they come here looking for me. A few bucks gives 'em the right to own every inch of you. So you just lay there. Let 'em work you over. Anything they want. Always kept saying "Next creep's gonna be my last one." 'Cause, you know, always had this feeling I could go out there anytime, get a decent job. So today I tried and what happened? [They] tell me I ain't got the right kind of voice.

Wanna know something? I won a beauty contest in high school. I was the prettiest girl in the whole school. For real. And you know what else? I was in love once. Really in love. When I was sixteen. Even made plans to get married. A young boy. My age. Handsome as anything. Real sensitive. Used to play the piano real nice. And he used to write me poems. Many nights, we used to go to his house, and he'd play the piano and recite the poems. Just for me. We loved each other a lot.

But then they killed him. The big, bad macho freaks in the town. They hated him 'cause I loved him and not 'em. They used to pick on him, torture him. One night they made him so ashamed – he didn't know how to swim – but he jumped in this lake, let the filthy waters take the life outta him. They killed him 'cause I loved him.

One night I was praying by his grave, and they came. They hurt me bad. After that, they followed me everywhere I went. Making demands. And I always had to give in to 'em, keep 'em from hurting me. You can't run away. They're everywhere, you know. Waiting to hurt you. But they can never take care of Lena! Oh, I know they think they can. I love when

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

they come here looking for Lena. I love showing 'em they ain't [nothin']. They try. They pay big bucks to try. They wanna see pleasure on my face, but all they get's one big laugh. That kills 'em. They hate that, you know. When you make fun of all that macho they come wrapped in. They come in to hurt Lena, but they can't They just make me laugh.

That's why I wanted to get that job. To come back here and yell out for all of 'em to hear. LENA AIN'T FOR SALE NO MORE! LENA'S FREE AGAIN! AND SHE'S GONNA STAY FREE THE REST OF HER LIFE! LISTEN TO ME, YOU CREEPS! LENA'S FREE AGAIN.

Wanted, you know, hear a new beat, a different parade. Nobody's cheap toy no more. Wanted to tell 'em all, hands off no matter how much. But, they won again - *(yelling into the night)* Yeah! Bring the studs in! Let 'em parade for Lena! Come on! Lena's waiting! Bring on the parade so Lena can die laughing!

(She laughs hysterically, then collapses on the stoop, shaking and crying)

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Joseph Lizardi
Book: Voices of Color: Scenes and Monologues from the Black American Theatre, pg 114)
ISBN: 978-1557831743
Publisher: Hal Leonard Corporation
Date (Month/Year): 1994

AWARD HISTORY

FL State Qualifier
IL State Finalist
KS State Qualifier

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY